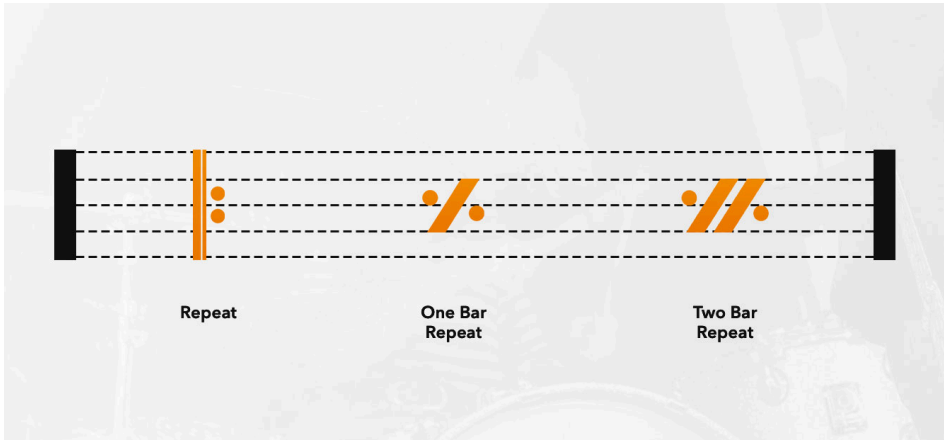


The one-bar repeat sign, resembling a per cent symbol, tells you to repeat the previous measure for one more bar. A two-bar repeat sign has a small "2" above the sign and signals that you should repeat the last two bars.



DRUM NOTATION VS. DRUM TABS

Drum notation and drum tabs are both ways of showing you drum parts written down, but they serve different purposes and are suited to different types of drummers. Drum notation is a more formal system, similar to sheet music, where each symbol represents a specific part of the drum kit and the timing of each beat. It's widely used in professional settings because it provides precise instructions on what to play and when.

Drum tabs, on the other hand, are a simplified version. They use horizontal lines and characters to indicate drum hits and rhythms.

Tabs are typically easier to read and are more popular among beginners or casual drummers who want to learn by following patterns rather than reading detailed music notation. However, they lack the nuance of traditional notation and may not be as useful for complex or professional performances.

PLAYING TECHNIQUES

DRUM TECHNIQUES

Drum playing techniques can add complexity and style to your playing. **Accents** are one of the most common techniques. This is where a particular note is played louder than others, highlighting a specific beat of a bar and adding a driving rhythm to your drumming. Similarly, **marcato** makes a single note stand out with force.

The **cross-stick (or rim-click)** technique produces a softer, wooden sound by striking the rim of the snare with the stick. **Ghost notes** take these quieter dynamics one step further and add texture to a beat. They're barely audible, created by light strokes on the snare.

Flams involve two hits close together, while **drags** consist of two quick strokes followed by a main note. Finally, the **rimshot** creates a sharp, loud sound by hitting the drumhead and rim simultaneously.

CYMBAL TECHNIQUES

Cymbal techniques add texture and dynamics. One common method is the **crash bell**, where you strike the bell of the cymbal to create a sharp, ringing sound. You can use the shoulder of the stick to get a louder tone.

The **choke crash** technique involves hitting the crash cymbal and immediately grabbing it with your hand to mute the sound, giving a short, tight accent. In contrast, the **splash cymbal** offers a quick burst of sound, perfect for lighter sections.

With the hi-hat, you have the choice between **open** and **closed** techniques. An **open hi-hat** is played by releasing the foot pedal, allowing the cymbals to vibrate freely, producing a 'washy' sound. **Closed hi-hats** are created by pressing the pedal down, giving a crisp, controlled tone.

ROLLS

When learning to read drum rolls in notation, you'll encounter several types that add texture to your playing. An **open roll** is performed by quickly striking two notes with each hand, creating a clear, sustained rhythm. It's one of the most common rudiments for drummers and can be used in various musical styles.

A **buzz roll**, or closed roll, involves rapidly bouncing the stick on the drumhead, resulting in a continuous, smooth sound. A more intense version is the **crushed buzz roll**, where the strokes are even closer together, creating a denser texture.

These rolls require control to maintain evenness while balancing the dynamics of the rhythm.

Each roll type is notated differently, so being familiar with the symbols and developing hand technique is key to playing them smoothly.

It may be useful to practise these rolls on a practice pad first. We recommend [the RealFeel by Evans Practice Pad](#). It fits perfectly on a snare which makes it easy to incorporate during practice and allows for a full range of movement when performing your roll.



OUR TIPS FOR READING DRUM MUSIC NOTATION

1. MASTER ONE SECTION BEFORE MOVING ON TO THE NEXT

Working on one section at a time will also help you get quicker at identifying symbols on the staff and will build your confidence in stages. Once you feel comfortable, move on to the next section. Your muscle memory will thank you, too!

2. FAMILIARISE YOURSELF WITH DRUM NOTATION SYMBOLS

At the same time as working on one bar at a time, make sure to familiarise yourself thoroughly with drum notation symbols and where they sit on the staff. It's important to memorise them so you can read a full piece of music without hesitation.

Start with the most common symbols, like the bass, snare, and hi-hat, and gradually expand to more complex markings as your skills grow. Additionally, pay attention to specific markings for techniques like ghost notes, accents, or rimshots, which will add complexity and depth to your playing.

Ghost notes are usually written smaller, while accents have symbols above them, indicating where you should hit harder.

3. PRACTISE COUNTING RHYTHMS ALOUD

Rhythm is the backbone of drum music. Being able to read the notes means little if you don't understand the timing.

Counting rhythms aloud helps you internalise note values and rests. Start with simple quarter notes, which are the most common, and work your way up to more intricate patterns like triplets or syncopated rhythms.

Speaking the beats out loud solidifies your understanding and strengthens your sense of timing. It's particularly useful when you're dealing with syncopation or odd time signatures, where rhythms might feel unfamiliar.

For instance, when playing 4/4 time, count "1 and 2 and 3 and 4" to keep your timing precise. For more complex time signatures, break it down similarly. This technique helps synchronise what you see on the sheet with what you play, making it easier to stay in time and lock in with the rest of the band.

4. PLAY ALONG WITH A METRONOME

Timing is everything when reading drum notation. Using a metronome ensures that you stay on tempo and maintain a consistent rhythm. It's a good idea to practise slowly at first, ensuring that each note is played with precision. Gradually increase the tempo as you improve.

A metronome helps keep you in time and prevents rushing or dragging, especially when tackling more complex rhythms. We recommend [Tama RW200 Rhythm Watch](#) for its tap tempo feature (letting you tap in the tempo).

5. BREAK DOWN COMPLEX RHYTHMS INTO SMALLER PARTS

When faced with a complicated rhythm, break it down into smaller chunks. Focus on a few beats or one bar at a time. If you encounter syncopation or polyrhythms, separate the hands and feet to understand how each part fits together. This approach makes difficult passages more manageable and less intimidating.

Once you've mastered the individual components, piece them back together for the full effect. Focus on accuracy – once you're playing the pattern cleanly at a slow pace, you can gradually increase the speed until you reach the song's intended tempo. It's a method that builds your control and endurance without compromising the quality of your playing.



HAVE A GREAT PRACTICE SESSION WITH THESE DRUM ACCESSORIES

A solid practice session requires more than just your drum kit. The right accessories can make all the difference in helping you progress faster and more efficiently. Below are a few essential items to consider for your setup.

DRUMSTICKS

Investing in the right pair of drumsticks can enhance your playing experience. Lighter sticks are ideal for beginners, as they're easier to handle, helping to reduce fatigue during longer sessions.

Look for sticks with a good grip and balanced weight, such as the [Vater Power 5A Wood Tip Drumsticks](#). Rubber-coated or ergonomic options can prevent slipping and make practising more comfortable over time.

responsibility to use hearing protection to prevent damage to your hearing. Headphones can protect your ears during long practice sessions.

Some models are designed specifically for drummers, reducing the harmful frequencies without affecting the sound quality too much. This way, you can enjoy your practice without worrying about long-term hearing issues.

The [Vic Firth SIH2 Stereo Isolation Headphones](#) are commonly used with electronic drum kits and can reduce noise by 25 decibels. They're a great pair to protect your hearing in both studio and live environments.

STICK HOLDERS

A stick holder is a small but useful accessory that keeps your drumsticks easily accessible – whether it's mounted on your kit or attached to your belt. Something simple like the [Drumstick Holder by Gear4music](#) is ideal and can make for a neater setup.

DRUM THRONES

A comfortable and adjustable drum throne is essential for maintaining good posture. A stable seat supports your lower back and keeps you balanced, which helps you avoid strain, especially during extended practice.

Look for one with height adjustability to suit your playing style, such as the [Mapex T670 Round Seat Drum Throne](#).

DRUM MUTES

Drum mutes are excellent for quiet practice. They're perfect for drummers who are practising in noise-sensitive environments like shared living spaces or flats. These soft pads fit over your drumheads and cymbals, significantly reducing sound while preserving the feel of playing on an acoustic set.

We recommend the [SoundOff by Evans Drum Mute Pack](#) for anyone looking to improve their drumming without making too much noise.

FAQS

HOW DO YOU NOTATE A DRUMROLL?

A drumroll is notated by a slash or two slashes through the stem of the note. This indicates that the drum should be hit repeatedly.

HOW DO I COUNT DRUM NOTATION?

To count the beats in your drum notation, you need to look at the time signature. The top number shows the number of beats in a measure, whilst the bottom number shows you each beat's value.

WHAT IS THE Z ON DRUM NOTATION?

The Z on drum notation represents a buzz stroke, typically used for snare drum techniques. This is a sustained, rapid vibration of the drumstick on the drumhead, creating a "buzzing" sound rather than a single clear hit. It's often used in rolls and rhythmic textures.

FINAL THOUGHTS

Learning how to read **drum music notation** can give you a deeper understanding of drumming and open up a world of new techniques to you. By understanding the different symbols, time signatures, and note values, you'll be able to interpret sheet music more accurately and explore a broader range of rhythms.

Remember to take it step by step and work at a pace that suits you best. Do you have any other tips for learning to read drum notation? Leave us a comment below!

For further reading, check out some of our other drum guides:

[How to Record Drums – A Guide to Getting the Clearest Drum Sound](#)

[The 12 Best Beginner Drum Sets to Kick-Start Your Drumming Career](#)

[The 9 Best Cymbal Brands to Suit All Drummers](#)

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Meg White: The White Stripes Drummer's Style, Kit, and Influence

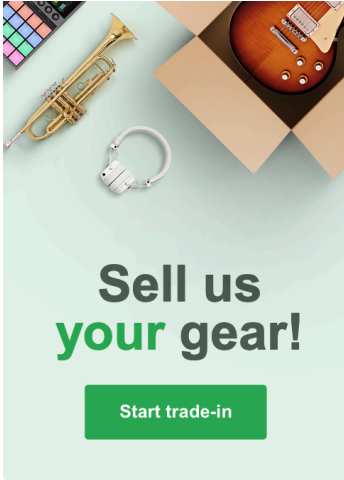
How Drums are Made – A Guide to Materials and Industry Processes

From Childhood Dreams to World-Class Drummer: Frank Zummo on Life Behind the Kit

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BETHANY

CONTENT WRITER - DRUMS

Beth is a drummer and songwriter from Hull. Having played music from an early age, Beth has been writing and producing original work with All Gone South, a five-piece band who began their journey in their early teens. After achieving a degree and master's in Music at Leeds Conservatoire, Beth's experience provides a great foundation for a future career in the industry. Beth continues to follow her passion within music, playing in a multitude of bands within East Yorkshire.



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